Chapter 17 — Spring AI and What's New in Boot 4 / Framework 7

This chapter has two halves.

The first half is **Spring AI**: the Spring project for calling large language models (LLMs) from a Spring application. It gives you one API for many AI providers (the companies or tools that host the models: OpenAI, Anthropic, Google, Amazon Bedrock, Ollama, ...). It also covers the things a real AI feature needs besides "send text, get text": prompt templates (the **prompt** is the text you send to the model), conversation memory, turning answers into Java objects, letting the model call your code (tools), searching your own documents (RAG, retrieval-augmented generation, §17.9), and the Model Context Protocol (MCP: a standard way to offer tools to AI apps, §17.10).

The second half is a **migration map**: what changed from Spring Boot 3.x to 4.x, from Spring Framework 6 to 7, and from Spring Security 6 to 7. Each change points to the chapter of this book that teaches it.

This chapter does **not** re-teach how LLMs work. For tokens (the word pieces a model reads and writes, and is billed by), context windows (the maximum amount of text one call can hold), sampling (how the model picks each next token), prompting, embeddings (lists of numbers that capture a text's meaning, §17.9), RAG design and agents (programs where a model repeatedly decides which tool to call next), read the AI book: LLMs, prompt engineering, building LLM apps, embeddings, vector databases and RAG, evaluation and agents. Here we focus on the **Spring way** of doing those things.

What you'll learn

1. What Spring AI is, which version fits Boot 4.1, and its building blocks (§17.1).
2. How to set up a project for a real provider (OpenAI, Anthropic) and how to run everything **offline** with a fake model (§17.2–17.3).
3. `ChatClient`, messages and prompt templates (§17.3–17.4).
4. Advisors: logging, a custom redaction advisor, and chat memory (§17.5–17.6).
5. Structured output into Java records (§17.7).
6. Tool calling: the model asks, Spring runs your method (§17.8).
7. RAG with `SimpleVectorStore`, an embedding model and `QuestionAnswerAdvisor` (§17.9).
8. MCP servers and clients (§17.10), and production concerns (§17.11).
9. The Boot 3 → 4 migration table (§17.13), Framework 6 → 7 (§17.14), Security 6 → 7 (§17.15) and Boot 4.1 additions (§17.16).

The code. `code/spring-ai-offline/` is a Spring Boot 4.1.1 project (Framework 7.0, Java 25) using **Spring AI 2.0.1**. It needs **no API key** (the secret string a provider gives you to authenticate and bill your calls) **and no network**: the `ChatModel` bean is a small fake that returns canned (pre-written) answers (`FakeChatModel`), and the `EmbeddingModel` bean is a word-hashing fake (`FakeEmbeddingModel`). Everything *above* the model — `ChatClient`, advisors, memory, tool calling, structured output, the vector store — is the real Spring AI code. All output shown is real `mvn -q -B -ntp verify` output (14 tests, all passing). Snippets that need a real provider are marked **(needs an API key — not run)**.

17.1 What Spring AI is

What it is

Spring AI is a Spring project that connects Spring applications to AI models. It does for AI providers what Spring Data does for databases: it gives you **portable interfaces** (`ChatModel`,

`EmbeddingModel`, `VectorStore`, ...), **Boot starters** that auto-configure a provider from properties, and a **fluent client** (`ChatClient`) for everyday use.

Analogy: `RestClient` (Chapter 6) hides the HTTP library under one API. `ChatClient` hides the AI provider under one API. Switching from OpenAI to Anthropic is mostly a change of starter and properties, not of code.

Why it matters

Calling an LLM's HTTP API directly is easy for a demo. A production feature also needs:

- prompt templates kept outside the code;
- conversation memory (the model itself remembers nothing between calls);
- answers converted into typed Java objects;
- tool calling (the model asks your application to run a function);
- retrieval of your own documents (RAG);
- logging, metrics, tracing, retries, and tests that do not call a paid API.

Spring AI provides each of these as a Spring building block, so they plug into things you already know: beans, properties, Micrometer observations (Chapter 15) and Boot tests (Chapter 12).

Versions (verified September 2026)

Spring AI	Released	Works with	Notes
1.0	May 2025	Boot 3.4 / 3.5	first GA (general availability: the first production-ready release)
1.1	Nov 2025	Boot 3.4 / 3.5	MCP annotations, more providers
2.0	**Jun 2026**	**Boot 4.0 / 4.1, Framework 7**	Jackson 3, JSpecify null-safety (annotations that mark what may be `null`), tool loop moved into advisors, immutable (unchangeable once built) options, MCP Java SDK 2.0. **Current: 2.0.1** (used here)

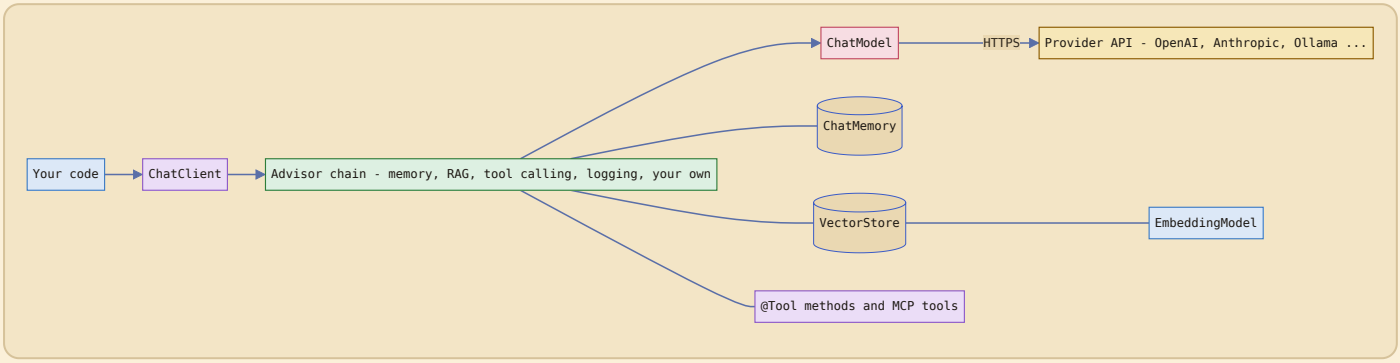
Spring AI 2.0 **requires** Boot 4. A Boot 3.5 application stays on Spring AI 1.1.x until it migrates. Note that 2.0.0's starters were built against Boot 4.1 dependency versions (spring-ai issue #6465), so Boot 4.1.x is the smoothest choice.

Spring AI is a separate project with its own version number. Boot does not manage its version, so you import the **Spring AI BOM** (bill of materials — a POM that pins the versions of a family of artifacts):

```
<dependencyManagement>
  <dependencies>
    <dependency>
      <groupId>org.springframework.ai</groupId>
      <artifactId>spring-ai-bom</artifactId>
      <version>2.0.1</version>
      <type>pom</type>
      <scope>import</scope>
    </dependency>
  </dependencies>
</dependencyManagement>
```

The building blocks

Building block	What it does	Real implementations
`ChatModel`	low-level: sends a `Prompt` (list of messages + options), returns a `ChatResponse`	`OpenAiChatModel`, `AnthropicChatModel`, `OllamaChatModel`, ... (our `FakeChatModel`)
`ChatClient`	the fluent, everyday API on top of a `ChatModel`, with advisors	one implementation, built from a `ChatClient.Builder`
Advisor	an interceptor around every `ChatClient` call (like a servlet filter)	logging, memory, RAG, tool calling, safeguard, validation
`ChatMemory`	stores past messages per conversation	`MessageWindowChatMemory` over in-memory / JDBC / other repositories
Structured output	converts the text answer into a Java type	`BeanOutputConverter`, `.entity(...)`
`ToolCallback` / `@Tool`	a Java method the model may ask to run	method tools, function tools, MCP tools
`EmbeddingModel`	turns text into a vector (a fixed-length list) of numbers	OpenAI, Ollama, ONNX transformers, ... (our `FakeEmbeddingModel`)
`VectorStore`	stores document vectors and finds similar ones	`SimpleVectorStore` (in memory), PgVector (a PostgreSQL extension for vectors), Redis, Elasticsearch, Qdrant, ...
MCP	standard protocol to expose / consume tools across processes	MCP server and client starters



Self-check

1. Which Spring AI version goes with Boot 4.1? → 2.0.x (2.0.1 at the time of writing).
2. Why do you import a BOM? → Spring AI is versioned separately from Boot; the BOM keeps all `spring-ai-*` artifacts on the same version.
3. What is the difference between `ChatModel` and `ChatClient`? → `ChatModel` is the provider-level interface (one prompt in, one response out). `ChatClient` is the fluent API on top, with advisors, templates, tools and output conversion.

17.2 Setting up a project

With a real provider (needs an API key — not run)

1. Add the BOM (above) and **one model starter**:

```
<!-- OpenAI -->
<dependency>
  <groupId>org.springframework.ai</groupId>
  <artifactId>spring-ai-starter-model-openai</artifactId>
</dependency>
<!-- or Anthropic (Claude) -->
<dependency>
  <groupId>org.springframework.ai</groupId>
  <artifactId>spring-ai-starter-model-anthropic</artifactId>
</dependency>
```

2. Configure it. Keep the key in an environment variable or a secret store, **never** in Git (Chapter 3 explains `${...}` placeholders):

```
# OpenAI (needs an API key — not run)
spring.ai.openai.api-key=${OPENAI_API_KEY}
spring.ai.openai.chat.model=gpt-5-mini
spring.ai.openai.chat.temperature=0.2
spring.ai.openai.embedding.model=text-embedding-3-small
```

```
# Anthropic (needs an API key — not run)
spring.ai.anthropic.api-key=${ANTHROPIC_API_KEY}
spring.ai.anthropic.chat.model=claude-sonnet-5-5
# a larger model for harder tasks: claude-opus-5-5
spring.ai.anthropic.chat.max-tokens=4096
```

3. Inject `ChatClient.Builder` and use it. (In the properties above, `temperature` controls randomness — lower is more predictable — and `max-tokens` caps the length of the answer.) The code in the rest of this chapter works unchanged with either provider.

Facts worth knowing about Spring AI 2.0 configuration (from the 2.0 upgrade notes):

Change in 2.0	Before (1.x)	Now (2.0)
option properties are **flat**	`spring.ai.openai.chat.options.model=...`	`spring.ai.openai.chat.model=...`
Anthropic module	Spring's own `AnthropicApi` client	the official `anthropic-java` SDK (software development kit: the vendor's own client library); default `max-tokens` raised from 500 to 4096
OpenAI modules	three variants (`openai`, `openai-sdk`, `azure-openai`)	one `spring-ai-openai` (Azure/Microsoft Foundry through its properties)
options objects	mutable, `copy()`	immutable, `mutate()`; `ChatClient.options(...)` takes a **builder**
several model starters on the classpath	—	pick one with `spring.ai.model.chat=openai` / `anthropic` / ...

Default models change over time (Spring AI 2.0's OpenAI default is `gpt-5-mini`, Anthropic's is `claude-haiku-4-5`). Always set the model explicitly so an upgrade does not silently change cost and behaviour.

Offline, as in this chapter

Our `pom.xml` has the BOM plus these artifacts and **no model starter**:

Artifact	Why
`spring-boot-starter`	a plain (non-web) Boot app
`spring-ai-autoconfigure-model-chat-client`	auto-configures a `ChatClient.Builder` bean from whatever `ChatModel` bean exists
`spring-ai-autoconfigure-model-tool`	the tool-calling manager and its properties (an *optional* dependency of the previous one, so you add it yourself — without it Boot logs `TypeNotPresentException ... ToolCallingAutoConfiguration`)
`spring-ai-autoconfigure-model-chat-memory`	a `ChatMemory` bean (window of the last 20 messages, stored in memory)
`spring-ai-vector-store`, `spring-ai-vector-store-advisor`	`SimpleVectorStore` and `QuestionAnswerAdvisor`

A model starter would pull these in for you. Then we declare our own `ChatModel` and `EmbeddingModel` beans (`AiConfig`):

```
@Configuration
public class AiConfig {

    /** With a real starter on the classpath, Boot would create OpenAiChatModel / AnthropicChatModel
here. */
    @Bean
    FakeChatModel chatModel() { return new FakeChatModel(); }

    @Bean
    EmbeddingModel embeddingModel() { return new FakeEmbeddingModel(); }
    // ... vectorStore and supportClient beans, shown later
}
```

Why a fake model?

A **fake** (a test double with simple working logic, see Chapter 12) lets you test everything around the model without cost, network, rate limits or random answers. Real LLM output is **non-deterministic**: the same prompt can give different words each time. Tests that assert exact LLM text are flaky. The usual strategy:

What you test	How
your prompts, advisors, tools, parsing, error handling	fake or stub `ChatModel` — fast, deterministic (same result every run), runs in CI (continuous integration: the server that builds and tests every change)
"is the answer good?"	a small **evaluation** set run against the real model, scored by rules or by another model (Spring AI has `RelevancyEvaluator` and `FactCheckingEvaluator`); see AI 8.5
the provider integration	a few tagged integration tests with a real key, run on demand

---

17.3 `ChatModel` and `ChatClient`

`ChatModel`: the provider contract

`ChatModel` has one essential method: `ChatResponse call(Prompt prompt)`. A `Prompt` is a list of **messages** plus **options** (model, temperature, tools, ...). A `ChatResponse` holds one or more `Generation`s, each with an `AssistantMessage`.

Message type	Class	Who writes it
system	`SystemMessage`	you: the rules and persona (the role the model should play: "You are a support assistant...")
user	`UserMessage`	the end user's question (often via a template)
assistant	`AssistantMessage`	the model's reply; may contain **tool calls** instead of text
tool	`ToolResponseMessage`	your application: the result of a tool the model asked for

Our fake implements exactly this interface (`FakeChatModel`). It records each prompt so tests can show what reached "the model", then applies a few rules:

```
public class FakeChatModel implements ChatModel {

    private final List<Prompt> received = new CopyOnWriteArrayList<>();

    @Override
    public ChatResponse call(Prompt prompt) {
        received.add(prompt);                                   // remember what the model was sent
        return new ChatResponse(List.of(new Generation(reply(prompt))));
    }

    /** Tool-calling-capable default options, like a real provider's options class. */
    @Override
    public ChatOptions getOptions() {
        return ToolCallingChatOptions.builder().build();
    }

    private AssistantMessage reply(Prompt prompt) {
        Message last = prompt.getInstructions().getLast();
        if (last instanceof ToolResponseMessage toolResult) { /* Rule 1: explain the tool result */ }
        String user = prompt.getUserMessage().getText();
        // Rule 2: tools offered + an order id in the question -> return an AssistantMessage with a
ToolCall
        // Rule 3: "JSON Schema" in the prompt -> return JSON in a ```json fence
        // Rule 4: RAG context present -> answer from its first line
        // Rule 5: "what is my name" -> look for "my name is X" in earlier messages
        return new AssistantMessage("(fake model) You asked: " + user);
    }
    // ...
}
```

`getOptions()` matters: `ChatClient` copies tool definitions into the prompt's options only when the model's options type supports tools (`ToolCallingChatOptions`). Every real provider's options class does.

`ChatClient`: the everyday API

Boot auto-configures a **prototype-style** (a new instance per injection, instead of one shared instance) `ChatClient.Builder` bean: each injection point gets its own builder, already wired to the `ChatModel` bean and to observability. You customise it and `build()` a `ChatClient`, which is thread-safe (safe to share between threads) and meant to be reused (make it a bean).

```
@SpringBootTest
class ChatClientTests {

    @Autowired ChatClient.Builder builder;    // auto-configured by Spring AI from the ChatModel bean
    @Autowired FakeChatModel model;

    @Test
    void simplestCall() {
        ChatClient chat = builder.build();
        String answer = chat.prompt()          // start a request
                .user("What is Spring AI?")    // the user message
                .call()                        // blocking call (use .stream() for a Flux)
                .content();                    // just the text of the reply
        System.out.println("answer: " + answer);
        assertThat(answer).isEqualTo("(fake model) You asked: What is Spring AI?");
    }
}
```

Output:

```
answer: (fake model) You asked: What is Spring AI?
```

What `call()` can return:

Method	Returns	Use when
`.content()`	`String`	you only need the text
`.entity(Type.class)`	your Java type	structured output (§17.7)
`.chatResponse()`	`ChatResponse`	you need metadata: token usage, finish reason (why the model stopped, e.g. done or hit the length limit), model id
`.chatClientResponse()`	response + advisor context	you need what advisors stored, e.g. the retrieved documents
`.stream().content()`	`Flux<String>`	show tokens as they arrive (chat UIs, SSE — Chapter 13)

Common mistakes

- Creating a new `ChatClient` for every request instead of one bean per use case.
- Injecting `ChatModel` and calling it directly everywhere, losing advisors, memory and observability. Use `ChatClient` unless you are writing infrastructure.
- Assuming the model remembers the previous call. It does not (§17.6).

17.4 Prompts and prompt templates

What it is

A **prompt template** is text with placeholders, filled at run time — the same idea as a SQL query with bind parameters (`?` placeholders whose values are supplied separately). Spring AI's `PromptTemplate`

uses `{name}` placeholders by default (rendered by the StringTemplate engine; the delimiters can be changed with `StTemplateRenderer` if your text contains braces, e.g. JSON examples).

How it works

1. Write the template, inline or in a file such as `prompts/explain.st`: `Explain {topic} to a {audience} in at most {words} words.`
2. Supply values with `render(Map)` / `create(Map)`, or with `.param(...)` on `ChatClient`.
3. A **missing** value is an error, not an empty string — so a typo fails fast.

```
PromptTemplate template = new PromptTemplate(
        "Explain {topic} to a {audience} in at most {words} words.");
String text = template.render(Map.of("topic", "dependency injection", "audience", "beginner", "words",
50));

PromptTemplate fromFile = new PromptTemplate(new ClassPathResource("prompts/explain.st"));
Prompt prompt = fromFile.create(Map.of("topic", "virtual threads", "audience", "Java developer",
"words", 80));

new PromptTemplate("Hello {name}, your plan is {plan}.").render(Map.of("name", "Ana"));   // throws
```

Output (`PromptTemplateTests`):

```
rendered: Explain dependency injection to a beginner in at most 50 words.
prompt messages: 1, user text: Explain virtual threads to a Java developer in at most 80 words.
missing variable -> IllegalStateException: Not all variables were replaced in the template. Missing
variable names are: [plan].
```

With `ChatClient`, templates and a system message look like this:

```
@Value("classpath:prompts/explain.st") Resource explainTemplate;

ChatClient chat = builder.defaultSystem("You are a concise Java tutor.").build();
chat.prompt()
    .user(u -> u.text(explainTemplate)
                .param("topic", "records")
                .param("audience", "beginner")
                .param("words", 40))
    .call()
    .content();
```

Output — the messages the model actually received:

```
messages the model received:
  SYSTEM: You are a concise Java tutor.
  USER: Explain records to a beginner in at most 40 words.
```

`defaultSystem(...)`, `defaultUser(...)`, `defaultAdvisors(...)`, `defaultTools(...)` and `defaultOptions(...)` on the builder apply to every request of that client. The per-request `.system(...)`, `.user(...)`, `.advisors(...)`, `.tools(...)` and `.options(...)` add to or override them.

Common mistakes

- Concatenating user input into the **system** message. User text belongs in the user message. Mixing them makes **prompt injection** (text crafted to override your instructions to the model) easier (see AI 9.4).

- Templates buried in Java strings. Put long prompts in `src/main/resources/prompts/*.st` files so they can be reviewed and versioned like code.
- Putting JSON examples with `{...}` in a template without changing the delimiters — the renderer treats the braces as placeholders.

Self-check

1. What happens if a template variable is missing? → `IllegalStateException` listing the missing names.
2. Where should long prompts live? → In classpath resource files, loaded as `Resource`.

17.5 Advisors

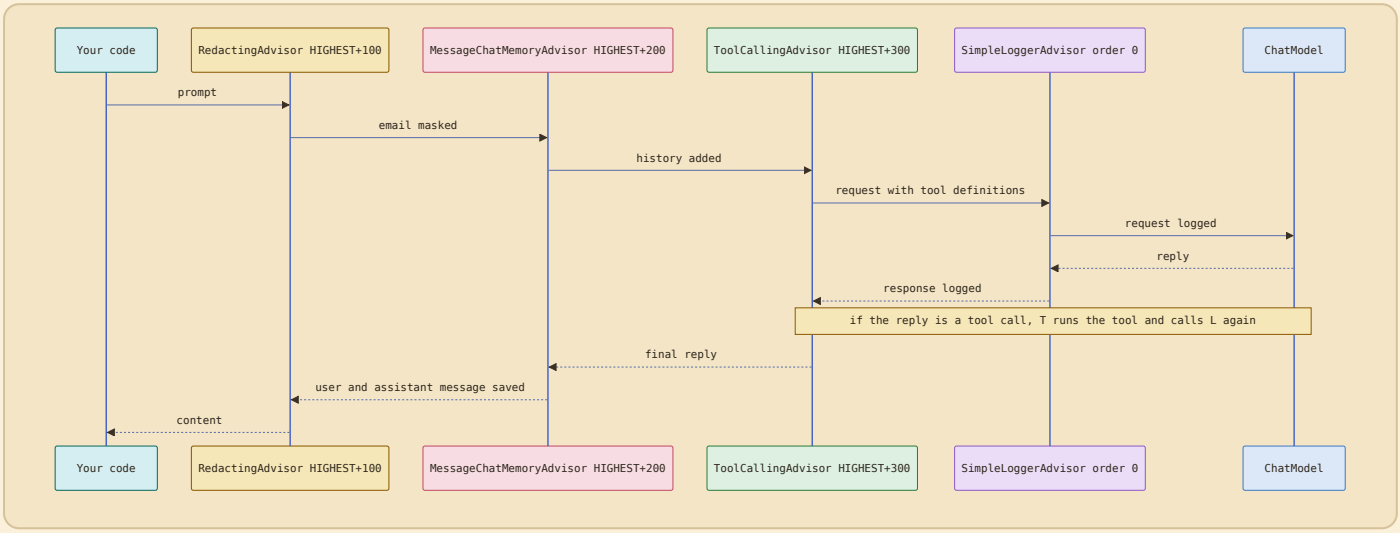
What it is

An **advisor** intercepts every `ChatClient` call on the way **to** the model and on the way **back**. It can change the prompt (add memory, add retrieved documents, redact — hide — data), change the response, or short-circuit the call (answer itself without calling the model). Advisors are to `ChatClient` what servlet filters are to Spring MVC (5.11) and what `@Around` advice is to AOP (Chapter 4).

How it works

1. `ChatClient` builds a `ChatClientRequest` (the `Prompt` + a shared **context** map).
2. Advisors are sorted by `getOrder()` — **lower runs first** on the way in and **last** on the way out.
3. Each advisor calls `chain.nextCall(request)` to pass control on. The last link calls the `ChatModel`.
4. The response travels back through the advisors in reverse order.

`HIGHEST` in the diagram is `Ordered.HIGHEST_PRECEDENCE` (the smallest `int`). The default orders are real Spring AI 2.0 values: memory advisors use `HIGHEST_PRECEDENCE + 200`, the auto-registered `ToolCallingAdvisor` `HIGHEST_PRECEDENCE + 300`, and `SimpleLoggerAdvisor` `0`. So the logger sits *inside* the tool loop and logs every round trip to the model, while memory sits outside it and saves only the final exchange.



Built-in advisors (Spring AI 2.0)

Advisor	Purpose	Section
`SimpleLoggerAdvisor`	logs request and response at DEBUG	below
`MessageChatMemoryAdvisor`	adds past messages of the conversation to the prompt, saves the new exchange	§17.6
`VectorStoreChatMemoryAdvisor`	long-term memory: retrieves *relevant* past messages from a vector store	§17.6
`QuestionAnswerAdvisor`	simple RAG: similarity search (finding the stored texts closest in meaning) + context pasted into the user message	§17.9
`RetrievalAugmentationAdvisor`	modular RAG: query rewriting, expansion, retrieval, joining, augmentation	§17.9
`ToolCallingAdvisor`	runs the tool-call loop; **auto-registered** by `ChatClient` (new in 2.0; replaced the loop inside each `ChatModel`)	§17.8
`SafeGuardAdvisor`	blocks requests containing configured sensitive words	—
`StructuredOutputValidationAdvisor`	validates JSON output against the schema and asks the model to retry if it does not match (new in 2.0)	§17.7

A custom advisor: redacting e-mail addresses

Many companies must not send personal data to an external AI provider. An advisor is the right place to enforce that once, for every call (`RedactingAdvisor`):

```
public class RedactingAdvisor implements CallAdvisor {

    private static final String EMAIL = "[\\w.+-]+@[\\w-]+\\.[\\w.]+";

    @Override
    public ChatClientResponse adviseCall(ChatClientRequest request, CallAdvisorChain chain) {
        Prompt redacted = request.prompt().augmentUserMessage(
                user -> user.mutate().text(user.getText().replaceAll(EMAIL, "[email]")).build());
        return chain.nextCall(request.mutate().prompt(redacted).build());   // pass it on down the
chain
    }

    @Override
    public String getName() { return "RedactingAdvisor"; }

    /** Run BEFORE the memory advisor (HIGHEST_PRECEDENCE + 200) so the stored history is redacted
too. */
    @Override
    public int getOrder() { return Ordered.HIGHEST_PRECEDENCE + 100; }
}
```

- `CallAdvisor` handles blocking calls; implement `StreamAdvisor` too if you use `.stream()`. For simple before/after logic, `BaseAdvisor` gives you `before(...)` and `after(...)` hooks.
- Requests and prompts are **immutable**: you create a modified copy (`mutate()`) and pass it on.

The support client wires three advisors as defaults:

```
@Bean
ChatClient supportClient(ChatClient.Builder builder, ChatMemory chatMemory) {
    return builder
            .defaultSystem("You are a polite support assistant for Acme Shop. Answer briefly.")
            .defaultAdvisors(
                    MessageChatMemoryAdvisor.builder(chatMemory).build(),
                    new RedactingAdvisor(),
                    SimpleLoggerAdvisor.builder()        // logs at DEBUG; here: one short line each
way
                            .requestToString(req -> req.prompt().getUserMessage().getText())
                            .responseToString(res -> res.getResult().getOutput().getText())
                            .build())
            .build();
}
```

`SimpleLoggerAdvisor` logs at **DEBUG**, so enable `logging.level.org.springframework.ai.chat.client.advisor=DEBUG` (`application.properties`). By default it logs the whole request and response objects; the two functions above shorten them. The test sends `alice@example.com` and a question about shipping:

```
model saw:      Please send the invoice to [email]
memory stored:  Please send the invoice to [email]
LOG SimpleLoggerAdvisor    : request: Do you ship to Canada?
LOG SimpleLoggerAdvisor    : response: (fake model) You asked: Do you ship to Canada?
```

Because the redactor runs *before* the memory advisor, neither the model nor the stored history ever sees the address. With the order reversed, memory would store the raw address and send it again in every later prompt.

Common mistakes

- Wrong order. Memory must run before RAG and logging if you want them to see the history. Redaction must run before anything that stores or sends text.
- Forgetting to call `chain.nextCall(...)` — the model is never called.
- Logging full prompts in production. Prompts may contain personal data and are large. Spring AI's observations also keep prompt/completion content **out** of logs and traces by default (`spring.ai.chat.client.observations.log-prompt=false`).

In the interview

Q: What is an advisor in Spring AI? → An interceptor around every `ChatClient` call, ordered by `getOrder()`, that can modify the request (add memory, retrieved documents, redaction) or the response. Memory, RAG, logging and — since 2.0 — the tool-calling loop are all advisors.

- *Follow-up: how is it like something else in Spring?* → Like a servlet filter chain or AOP `@Around` advice: each link calls the next.
- *Follow-up: where do you enforce a "no personal data to the provider" rule?* → In an early advisor, so it applies to every call and to stored memory.

17.6 Chat memory

What it is

LLM APIs are **stateless** (the server keeps nothing between calls): each request must carry the whole conversation. "Memory" means your application stores past messages and **re-sends** the relevant ones.

Spring AI splits this into:

Piece	Role	Default
`ChatMemoryRepository`	stores messages per conversation id	`InMemoryChatMemoryRepository`; JDBC (`spring-ai-starter-model-chat-memory-repository-jdbc`), Cassandra, Neo4j, Redis, ...
`ChatMemory`	decides **which** messages to keep	`MessageWindowChatMemory`: the last **20** messages (system messages are kept)
memory advisor	loads history into the prompt, saves the new exchange	`MessageChatMemoryAdvisor` (history as messages) or `VectorStoreChatMemoryAdvisor` (relevant old messages from a vector store)

Why a window? The context window of a model is limited and every token costs money (AI 6.9). Long conversations need trimming or summarising.

How it works

1. Every call passes a **conversation id** (a user id, a chat session id).
2. The advisor loads that conversation's messages and puts them before the new user message.
3. After the reply, it saves the user message and the assistant reply.

In Spring AI **2.0 the conversation id is required at call time** (the old default id and the builder's `.conversationId(...)` were removed):

```
private String ask(String conversationId, String text) {
    return support.prompt()
            .user(text)
            .advisors(a -> a.param(ChatMemory.CONVERSATION_ID, conversationId))
            .call()
            .content();
}

ask("alice-42", "Hi, my name is Alice.");
ask("alice-42", "What is my name?");
ask("bob-7",    "What is my name?");
```

Output (`AdvisorTests`):

```
alice> (fake model) You asked: Hi, my name is Alice.
alice> Your name is Alice.
bob>   I don't know your name.
second call for alice-42 sent these messages to the model:
  SYSTEM: You are a polite support assistant for Acme Shop. Answer briefly.
  USER: Hi, my name is Alice.
  ASSISTANT: (fake model) You asked: Hi, my name is Alice.
  USER: What is my name?
```

The fake model has no memory of its own. It "knows" Alice's name only because the advisor re-sent the first exchange. Bob's conversation is separate. The test also asserts that the memory holds 4 messages for `alice-42` and 2 for `bob-7`.

Common mistakes

- Using one fixed conversation id for everybody — users see each other's history. Derive the id from the authenticated user and session (Chapter 10).
- In-memory repository in a cluster: each instance has different memory and it is lost on restart. Use the JDBC (or another shared) repository.

- Unbounded history: cost and latency grow with every turn. Keep a window; summarise older turns if needed.

Self-check

1. Does the model remember earlier calls? → No; the memory advisor re-sends stored messages.
2. What changed for conversation ids in 2.0? → They must be passed per call with `ChatMemory.CONVERSATION_ID`.
3. Which memory for three app instances behind a load balancer? → A shared repository such as JDBC.

17.7 Structured output

What it is

Structured output means getting the answer as data — a record, a list, a map — instead of free text. Spring AI does it with a **converter** that (1) appends format instructions with a **JSON Schema** (a standard JSON document that describes which fields and types a JSON value must have) of your type to the prompt, and (2) parses the reply into your type with Jackson 3. See AI 6.4 for why schemas help.

```
public record MovieRecommendation(String title, int year, List<String> genres, double score) {}

MovieRecommendation movie = builder.build().prompt()
        .user("Recommend one science-fiction movie about survival.")
        .call()
        .entity(MovieRecommendation.class);          // schema added, reply parsed
```

Output (`StructuredOutputTests`):

```
user message sent to the model (first 3 lines):
  | Recommend one science-fiction movie about survival.
  | Your response should be in JSON format.
  | Do not include any explanations, only provide a RFC8259 compliant JSON response following this
format without deviation.
  | ... (31 lines in total, including a JSON Schema)
parsed record: MovieRecommendation[title=The Martian, year=2015, genres=[sci-fi, survival], score=8.0]
```

Notice two things. The converter added about 30 lines to the prompt (tokens you pay for). And the fake replied with JSON **inside a Markdown code fence** (Markdown is the lightweight text-formatting syntax; a fence is the ``` wrapper around code) (```` ```json ````), which models often do; the converter strips the fence before parsing.

The converter can also be used on its own:

```
var converter = new BeanOutputConverter<>(MovieRecommendation.class);
MovieRecommendation m = converter.convert("""
        {"title":"Arrival","year":2016,"genres":["sci-fi","drama"],"score":7.9}""");
```

```
converted: MovieRecommendation[title=Arrival, year=2016, genres=[sci-fi, drama], score=7.9]
schema mentions the fields: true, true
```

Options

Option	How	Notes
a class / record	`.entity(MovieRecommendation.class)`	most common
generic types	`.entity(new ParameterizedTypeReference<List<MovieRecommendation>>() {})`	lists, maps
map / list converters	`MapOutputConverter`, `ListOutputConverter`	loose structures
native structured output	`.advisors(AdvisorParams.ENABLE_NATIVE_STRUCTURED_OUTPUT)`	the provider itself constrains the output to the schema (only for providers and models that support it, such as OpenAI; check your provider's Spring AI page) — more reliable than instructions
validation + retry	`StructuredOutputValidationAdvisor` (2.0)	checks the JSON against the schema; asks the model again on mismatch

Common mistakes

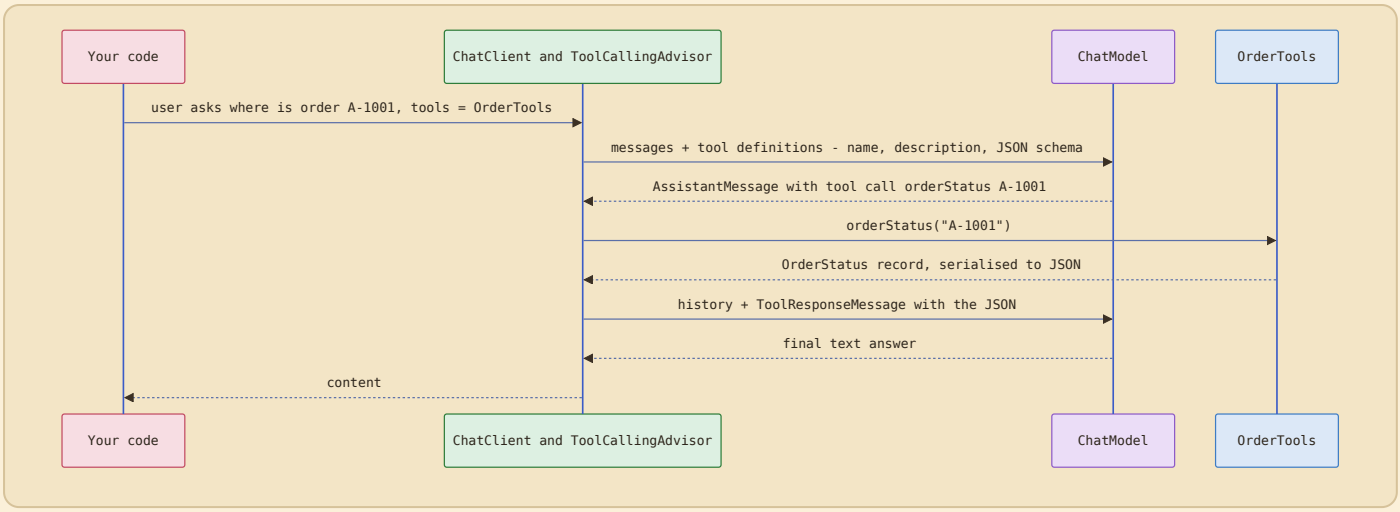
- Trusting the parsed object blindly. The model can still return wrong *values* with the right *shape*. Validate business rules (Bean Validation, 5.6).
- Huge nested types. The schema grows and costs tokens; keep output types small.
- Forgetting that parsing can fail. Catch the exception, retry once, or use the validation advisor.

17.8 Tool calling

What it is

Tool calling (function calling) lets the model ask your application to run a function — look up an order, check stock, call an API — and then answer with the result. The model **never runs code itself**: it only returns a request "call `orderStatus` with `{"orderId":"A-1001"}`". Your application decides whether to run it. See AI 6.5 and AI 9.3 for the concept.

How it works



1. You mark methods with `@Tool` and pass the object with `.tools(...)` (or `.defaultTools(...)` on the builder).
2. Spring AI generates a **tool definition** from the method: name, description, and a JSON Schema of the parameters.
3. The model replies with a **tool call** instead of text.
4. The `ToolCallingAdvisor` (auto-registered since 2.0) runs the method, converts the result to JSON, adds a `ToolResponseMessage`, and calls the model **again**.
5. The loop repeats until the model answers with text.

```
public class OrderTools {

    public record OrderStatus(String orderId, String status, String eta) {}

    @Tool(name = "orderStatus", description = "Look up the delivery status of an order by its id, e.g.
A-1001")
    public OrderStatus orderStatus(@ToolParam(description = "the order id") String orderId) {
        return new OrderStatus(orderId, "SHIPPED", "2026-10-02");   // a real app would call the order
service
    }
}

String answer = builder.build().prompt()
        .user("Where is my order A-1001?")
        .tools(new OrderTools())               // expose the @Tool methods for this request
        .call()
        .content();
```

Output (`ToolCallingTests`) — the test inspects the two prompts the model received:

```
model calls: 2
1) tools offered to the model: [orderStatus]
2) model asked for: orderStatus {"orderId":"A-1001"}
3) Spring ran the method, sent back: {"orderId":"A-1001","status":"SHIPPED","eta":"2026-10-02"}
4) final answer: Here is what I found via orderStatus: {"orderId":"A-
1001","status":"SHIPPED","eta":"2026-10-02"}
no tools -> (fake model) You asked: Where is my order A-1001?
```

One user question cost **two model calls**. Every tool round trip adds latency and tokens.

Details worth knowing (Spring AI 2.0)

Topic	Fact
description	the model decides *when* to call a tool from its **description** — write it like documentation for a new colleague
`returnDirect = true`	return the tool result straight to the caller without a second model call
`ToolContext`	pass hidden data (tenant id, user id) to tools with `.toolContext(Map)`; it is **not** sent to the model
limits	at most **40 calls per tool** and **150 in total** per request by default (`spring.ai.tools.limits.*`), to stop runaway (never-ending) loops
resolution	only tools attached to the request or client can run; resolving arbitrary beans by name is **off** by default in 2.0
errors	by default a tool exception is sent back to the model as an error message (`spring.ai.tools.throw-exception-on-error=false`) so it can recover
programmatic tools	`FunctionToolCallback` / `MethodToolCallback` build tools without annotations

Security: tools are an attack surface

Tools are an **attack surface** (a place where an attacker can try to get in). The model's tool arguments are **untrusted input**. A prompt-injection text in a retrieved document or user message can make the model call tools with harmful arguments. Rules:

- Check authorization **inside** the tool, for the real user (take the user from `ToolContext` or the security context, never from model-supplied arguments).
- Give tools the least power possible: read-only where you can, and a human confirmation step for anything irreversible (AI 9.4).
- Validate arguments like any request body.

In the interview

Q: Explain tool calling in Spring AI. → You annotate methods with `@Tool`; Spring AI sends their JSON-schema definitions with the prompt. When the model returns a tool call, the `ToolCallingAdvisor` executes the method, sends the result back as a tool message, and calls the model again until it produces a final answer. The model only *requests* calls; the application executes them.

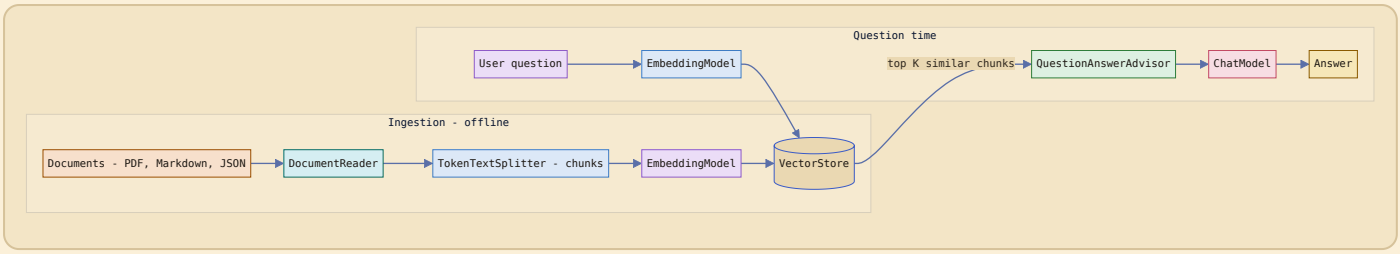
- *Follow-up: how do you stop an infinite loop?* → Tool-call limits (40 per tool, 150 total by default in 2.0) plus timeouts.
- *Follow-up: how do you pass the current user to a tool safely?* → `ToolContext` or the security context — never trust a user id argument chosen by the model.

17.9 RAG: retrieval-augmented generation

What it is

RAG answers questions from **your** documents: find the most relevant chunks, paste them into the prompt, and tell the model to answer only from them. It reduces made-up answers and lets you use private or fresh data without retraining (teaching the model new data, which is slow and expensive). The design questions (chunking — splitting documents into pieces, hybrid search — combining keyword

and meaning search, reranking — re-sorting results with a stronger model, access control, evaluation) are covered in AI Chapter 7; here is the Spring AI wiring.



Piece	Spring AI type	Examples
read	`DocumentReader`	`TextReader`, `JsonReader`, `MarkdownDocumentReader`, `PagePdfDocumentReader`, `TikaDocumentReader`
split	`TokenTextSplitter`	chunks of about 800 tokens by default
embed	`EmbeddingModel`	OpenAI `text-embedding-3-small`, Ollama, ONNX transformers (local)
store and search	`VectorStore`	`SimpleVectorStore` (in memory), PgVector, Redis, Elasticsearch, Qdrant, Milvus, ...
augment	advisor	`QuestionAnswerAdvisor` (simple), `RetrievalAugmentationAdvisor` (modular)

The embedding model and the vector store

An **embedding** is a list of numbers (a vector) representing a text, so that texts with similar meaning have vectors pointing in similar directions (AI 7.2). Similarity is usually the **cosine** of the angle between vectors: 1 = same direction, 0 = unrelated.

Our `FakeEmbeddingModel` is deliberately simple: it hashes each word (turns it into a number with a fixed function; stop words — very common words such as "the" — are skipped, and words are cut to 5 letters) into one of 256 slots and normalises the vector (scales it to length 1). Texts sharing words become similar. A real model captures *meaning* ("refund" is close to "money back"), which word hashing cannot.

```
@Bean
VectorStore vectorStore(EmbeddingModel embeddingModel) {
    SimpleVectorStore store = SimpleVectorStore.builder(embeddingModel).build();
    store.add(List.of(
            new Document("Refunds are issued to the original payment method within 5 business days.",
                    Map.of("source", "refund-policy.md")),
            new Document("Standard shipping takes 3 to 7 days. Express shipping arrives the next
day.",
                    Map.of("source", "shipping.md")),
            new Document("You can change your password under Settings, then Security.",
                    Map.of("source", "account.md"))));
    return store;
}
```

`add(...)` embeds each document and stores the vector with its text and **metadata** (source, tenant, date — used for filtering and citations).

```
List<Document> hits = vectorStore.similaritySearch(
        SearchRequest.builder().query("How long do refunds take?").topK(2).build());

List<Document> filtered = vectorStore.similaritySearch(SearchRequest.builder()
        .query("How long do refunds take?").topK(2).similarityThreshold(0.1).build());
```

Output (`RagTests`):

```
score 0.192  refund-policy.md   Refunds are issued to the original payment method within 5 business
days.
score 0.000  shipping.md        Standard shipping takes 3 to 7 days. Express shipping arrives the next
day.
with similarityThreshold(0.1): 1 document(s)
```

`topK(2)` always returns two documents, even an irrelevant one (score 0.000). A **similarity threshold** drops weak matches. Without it, RAG pastes noise into the prompt. Tune K and the threshold on real questions.

`QuestionAnswerAdvisor`

```java
ChatClient chat = builder
        .defaultAdvisors(QuestionAnswerAdvisor.builder(vectorStore)
                .searchRequest(SearchRequest.builder().topK(1).similarityThreshold(0.2).build())
                .build())
        .build();

String answer = chat.prompt().user("How fast is express shipping?").call().content();
```

Output — the user message after the advisor rewrote it:

```
augmented user message:
  | How fast is express shipping?
  |
  | Context information is below, surrounded by ---------------------
  |
  | ---------------------
  | Standard shipping takes 3 to 7 days. Express shipping arrives the next day.
  | ---------------------
  |
  | ...
answer: According to our docs: Standard shipping takes 3 to 7 days. Express shipping arrives the next
day.
```

The rest of the default template (cut above) tells the model to answer from the context and to say so when the answer is not there. You can replace the template with `.promptTemplate(...)`, and restrict the search per request with a **filter expression** on metadata, e.g. `a.param(QuestionAnswerAdvisor.FILTER_EXPRESSION, "tenant == 'acme'")` — this is how you enforce document-level permissions (AI 7.9). The retrieved documents are also stored in the response context under `QuestionAnswerAdvisor.RETRIEVED_DOCUMENTS`, which you can use to show citations.

For more control, `RetrievalAugmentationAdvisor` (module `spring-ai-rag`) builds a pipeline from parts: `RewriteQueryTransformer` / `CompressionQueryTransformer` (improve the query), `MultiQueryExpander`, `VectorStoreDocumentRetriever`, a `DocumentJoiner`, post-processors (e.g. reranking) and `ContextualQueryAugmenter`.

A production vector store (needs a database — not run)

`SimpleVectorStore` keeps everything in memory (it can `save` / `load` a JSON file) — fine for tests and demos, not for real data. With PostgreSQL + the `pgvector` extension:

```
<dependency>
  <groupId>org.springframework.ai</groupId>
  <artifactId>spring-ai-starter-vector-store-pgvector</artifactId>
</dependency>
```

```
# (needs PostgreSQL with pgvector — not run)
spring.datasource.url=jdbc:postgresql://localhost:5432/docs
spring.ai.vectorstore.pgvector.initialize-schema=true
spring.ai.vectorstore.pgvector.index-type=hnsw
spring.ai.vectorstore.pgvector.distance-type=cosine-distance
spring.ai.vectorstore.pgvector.dimensions=1536
```

`dimensions` must match the embedding model (1536 for `text-embedding-3-small`). Changing the embedding model means **re-embedding every document**. `hnsw` (Hierarchical Navigable Small World) is an approximate nearest-neighbour index (AI 7.3); `initialize-schema=true` is convenient in development, but in production create the table with Flyway (8.16).

Common mistakes

- No similarity threshold — irrelevant chunks confuse the model.
- Chunks too large (costly, diluted) or too small (no context). Start around a few hundred tokens with some overlap.
- Ignoring permissions: every user can retrieve every document. Store tenant/role in metadata and filter.
- Mixing embeddings from two different models in one store — the vectors are not comparable.

Self-check

1. What does `QuestionAnswerAdvisor` add to the prompt? → The top matching documents, wrapped in a template that says to answer from them.
2. Why a similarity threshold? → `topK` always returns K documents; the threshold drops weak matches.
3. What must match between the embedding model and a PgVector table? → The number of dimensions (and the model itself).

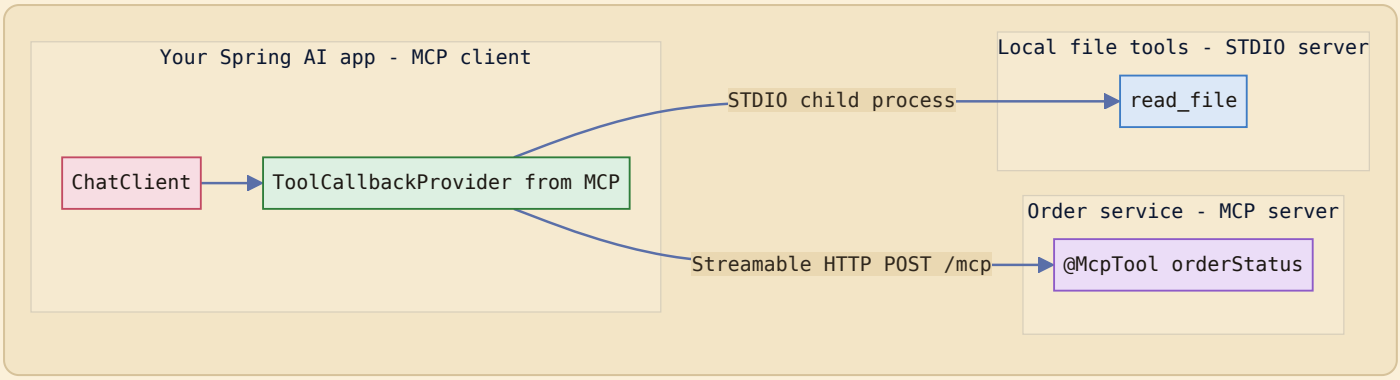
17.10 MCP: the Model Context Protocol

What it is

MCP is an open protocol (started by Anthropic in November 2024, now widely adopted) that standardises how an AI application discovers and calls **tools**, reads **resources** and uses **prompts** exposed by another process. Think "USB for AI tools": write a tool server once, and any MCP-capable host (Claude Desktop, IDE — code editor — assistants, your own Spring AI app) can use it. Concepts and security are in AI 6.10 and AI 9.8.

Role	What it does	Spring AI starter
MCP server	exposes tools/resources/prompts	`spring-ai-starter-mcp-server` (STDIO), `spring-ai-starter-mcp-server-webmvc`, `spring-ai-starter-mcp-server-webflux`
MCP client	connects to servers, turns their tools into `ToolCallback`s	`spring-ai-starter-mcp-client`, `spring-ai-starter-mcp-client-webflux`

Transports: **STDIO** (standard input/output: the host starts the server as a child process and they talk through its input and output streams — local tools) and **Streamable HTTP** (a remote server; the default for Spring AI 2.0's web servers, endpoint `POST /mcp`). The older SSE transport is deprecated since 2.0.



An MCP server (snippet — not run)

```
// spring-ai-starter-mcp-server-webmvc on the classpath
import org.springframework.ai.mcp.annotation.McpTool;
import org.springframework.ai.mcp.annotation.McpToolParam;
import org.springframework.stereotype.Component;

@Component
public class OrderMcpTools {

    @McpTool(name = "orderStatus", description = "Delivery status of an order by id")
    public OrderStatus orderStatus(@McpToolParam(description = "order id", required = true) String
orderId) {
        return orderService.status(orderId);
    }
}
```

```
spring.ai.mcp.server.name=order-tools
# already the default in 2.0 (endpoint /mcp); shown for clarity
spring.ai.mcp.server.protocol=STREAMABLE
```

In Spring AI 2.0 the MCP annotations live in `org.springframework.ai.mcp.annotation` (they came from the `org.springaicommunity.mcp` community project in 1.1). Beans with `@McpTool`, `@McpResource`, `@McpPrompt` methods are discovered automatically.

An MCP client (snippet — needs a running server, not run)

```
spring.ai.mcp.client.streamable-http.connections.orders.url=http://localhost:8081
# a local STDIO server, started by the client:
spring.ai.mcp.client.stdio.connections.files.command=npx
spring.ai.mcp.client.stdio.connections.files.args=-y,@modelcontextprotocol/server-
filesystem,/data/docs
```

```
@Bean
ChatClient agent(ChatClient.Builder builder, ToolCallbackProvider mcpTools) {
    return builder.defaultToolCallbacks(mcpTools).build();   // MCP tools behave like @Tool methods
}
```

The client auto-configuration exposes the remote tools as a `ToolCallbackProvider` bean (`spring.ai.mcp.client.toolcallback.enabled=true` by default), so the tool-calling loop from §17.8 works

unchanged.

Trade-offs

	In-process `@Tool`	MCP tool
latency	method call	network or process hop
reuse	this app only	any MCP host, any language
deployment	ships with the app	separate service, separate lifecycle
security	your normal code review	you now trust a remote server's tool descriptions and results — authenticate it (OAuth 2 for HTTP servers), allow-list (explicitly permit only named) tools, treat results as untrusted input

Use `@Tool` for logic that belongs to your application. Use MCP to share tools across teams or AI hosts, or to consume existing MCP servers.

17.11 Production concerns

Concern	What Spring AI gives you	Also see
observability	Micrometer observations: `spring.ai.chat.client`, `spring.ai.advisor`, `gen_ai.client.operation` (model call, with `gen_ai.client.token.usage` metrics), `spring.ai.tool`, `db.vector.client.operation`. Prompt/completion content is **not** recorded unless you enable `log-prompt` / `log-completion`	Chapter 15
cost	token usage in `chatResponse().getMetadata().getUsage()`	AI 6.6
retries and timeouts	provider SDK retries (e.g. `spring.ai.openai.chat.max-retries`, default 3) and `spring.ai.retry.*` for providers using Spring's retry; set HTTP timeouts	AI 6.7, 4.7
streaming	`.stream().content()` returns `Flux<String>`; send it to browsers with SSE	Chapter 13
blocking calls	model calls take seconds; on Spring MVC turn on virtual threads (`spring.threads.virtual.enabled=true`) so waiting threads are cheap	Java 15.4
safety	redaction advisor, `SafeGuardAdvisor`, output validation, tool permissions	AI Chapter 12
testing	fake `ChatModel` for logic, evaluators for quality	§17.2

Common mistakes (Spring AI, whole part)

- Calling the model inside a database transaction (Chapter 7): the transaction and its connection stay open for seconds.
- No timeout or limit on tool loops and output tokens.
- Letting the model's text reach SQL, shell commands or HTML without validation or escaping (neutralising special characters so text cannot act as code).
- Hard-coding a model id that the provider later retires — keep it in configuration.
- Tests that call the real API on every build.

In the interview

Q: How would you add an AI assistant to an existing Spring Boot service? → Add the Spring AI BOM and a model starter, configure the key and model in properties, build a `ChatClient` bean with a system prompt and advisors (memory with a per-user conversation id, RAG over our documents with metadata filters, logging/redaction), expose business functions as `@Tool` methods that check authorization themselves, and return typed results with `.entity(...)`. Test logic with a fake `ChatModel`, measure quality with an evaluation set, watch token usage and latency through Micrometer.

- *Follow-up: why Spring AI rather than the provider's SDK?* → Portability across providers, and the Spring integration: auto-configuration, observability, advisors, vector stores, testing. For one provider-specific feature you can still reach the native options.
- *Follow-up: how do you keep answers grounded (based only on real sources, not invented)?* → RAG with a similarity threshold, a template that says "answer only from the context", citations from retrieved-document metadata, and evaluation of faithfulness.

Spring AI TL;DR

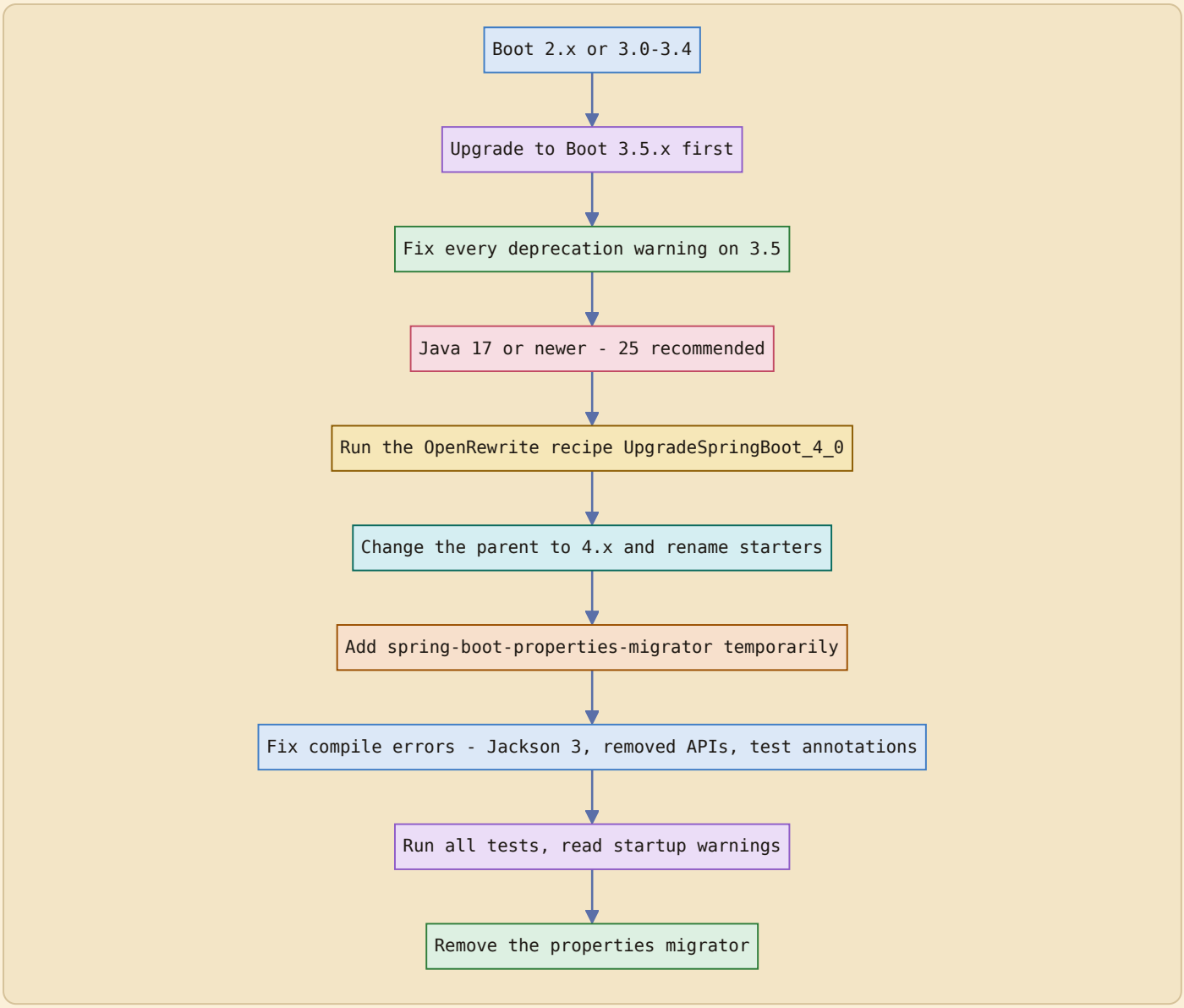
- Spring AI **2.0.x** for Boot 4 (1.1.x for Boot 3.5). Import `spring-ai-bom`, add one model starter, set `spring.ai.<provider>.api-key` and `...chat.model`.
- `ChatClient` = fluent API over `ChatModel`; `.content()`, `.entity(...)`, `.stream()`.
- **Advisors** wrap every call (ordered, lower first): logging, memory, RAG, tool calling, your own (redaction).
- **Memory** re-sends history; pass `ChatMemory.CONVERSATION_ID` per call; window of 20 by default.
- **Structured output**: schema instructions + Jackson parsing; native mode and validation advisor for reliability.
- **Tools**: `@Tool` methods; the model requests, `ToolCallingAdvisor` executes and loops (limits 40/150). Authorize inside tools.
- **RAG**: reader → splitter → `EmbeddingModel` → `VectorStore`; `QuestionAnswerAdvisor` with threshold and metadata filters.
- **MCP**: share tools across processes; `@McpTool` servers, client tools arrive as a `ToolCallbackProvider`.
- Test with a **fake model**; evaluate quality separately.

17.12 What's new: how to read the rest of this chapter

The Spring generation that arrived in **November 2025** (Framework 7.0 on 13 Nov, Boot 4.0 on 20 Nov, Security 7.0) is the biggest change since Boot 3 moved everything from `javax.*` to `jakarta.*` (Java's enterprise APIs — servlets, JPA, validation — were handed to the Eclipse Foundation as **Jakarta EE** and had to change package names). This book targets **Boot 4.1.1**, whose dependency BOM gives you Framework 7.0.9, Security 7.1.1, Hibernate ORM 7.4, Spring Data 2026.0, Jackson 3.1.5, Tomcat 11.0.24 and JUnit 6.0.3 (1.4).

The tables below are a **map**, not a second textbook: one line per change, with a pointer to the chapter that explains and demonstrates it. They were checked against the Boot 4.0 migration guide, the Boot 4.0 and 4.1 release notes, the Framework 7.0 release notes and the Spring Security 7 reference.

A safe upgrade path (Boot 3.x → 4.x)



1. **Go to 3.5 first.** The migration guide assumes 3.5; code deprecated (marked as "will be removed, stop using") in 3.x is removed in 4.0.
2. **Automate the boring part** with OpenRewrite (a tool that applies automated, rule-based source-code changes called *recipes*; not run here):

   ```
   mvn -U org.openrewrite.maven:rewrite-maven-plugin:run \
     -Drewrite.recipeArtifactCoordinates=org.openrewrite.recipe:rewrite-spring:RELEASE \
     -Drewrite.activeRecipes=org.openrewrite.java.spring.boot4.UpgradeSpringBoot_4_0
   ```

   It updates versions, renames starters and properties, and applies the Framework 7 / Security 7 sub-recipes. Review its diff (the list of line-by-line changes) like any other change.
3. `spring-boot-properties-migrator` (runtime dependency, temporarily) reports renamed/removed properties at startup and maps the old names for you while you fix them.
4. If you are stuck, the **"classic" starters** (`spring-boot-starter-classic`, `spring-boot-starter-test-classic`) bring back the old all-in-one auto-configuration jar layout to get you compiling, then move to the modular starters.

17.13 Spring Boot 3.x → 4.x migration table

Baselines

Item	Boot 3.x	Boot 4.x	Where in this book
Java	17+	17+ (25 recommended; this book uses 25)	1.4
Spring Framework	6.x	7.0	§17.14
Jakarta EE	10 (Servlet 6.0 — the Java web request/response API)	**11** (Servlet 6.1, JPA 3.2, Bean Validation 3.1)	1.4
Embedded servers	Tomcat 10.1, Jetty 12, Undertow	Tomcat 11, Jetty 12.1; **Undertow removed** (no Servlet 6.1 support)	Chapter 1
Hibernate ORM	6.x	7.x (7.4 in Boot 4.1)	Chapter 8
JUnit	5	**6** (JUnit 4 support in the TestContext framework deprecated)	Chapter 12
Kotlin / GraalVM	1.7+ / 22.3+	Kotlin 2.2+ / GraalVM 25+	Chapter 15
Gradle	7.x / 8.x	8.14+ or 9	1.6

Modularization and starters

Change	What to do	Where
`spring-boot-autoconfigure` split into **one module per technology** (`spring-boot-webmvc`, `spring-boot-jdbc`, `spring-boot-jackson`, ...) with its own starter and **test starter**	use the technology starters; imports of auto-configuration classes (for `exclude`) changed packages	3.14
`spring-boot-starter-web` → **`spring-boot-starter-webmvc`**	rename (the old name remains as a deprecated alias)	1.7
`spring-boot-starter-aop` → **`spring-boot-starter-aspectj`**	rename	4.2
`spring-boot-starter-oauth2-client` / `-resource-server` / `-authorization-server` → `spring-boot-starter-security-oauth2-...`	rename	Chapter 11
`spring-boot-starter-web-services` → `spring-boot-starter-webservices`	rename	—
test support per module: `spring-boot-starter-webmvc-test`, `-data-jpa-test`, `-restclient-test`, ...	add the test starter for each technology you test	Chapter 12
Flyway / Liquibase auto-configured only with **`spring-boot-starter-flyway`** / `-liquibase` (the library alone is no longer enough)	add the starter	8.16
`RestClient` / `RestTemplate` builders come from **`spring-boot-starter-restclient`**	add it for client code	Chapter 6
`@EntityScan` moved to `org.springframework.boot.persistence.autoconfigure`	fix the import	Chapter 8
`hibernate-jpamodelgen` → `hibernate-processor`	rename the annotation processor (a compiler plug-in that generates code from annotations)	Chapter 8
Spring Batch runs **without a database** by default	use `spring-boot-starter-batch-jdbc` for JDBC job metadata	—

Jackson 3

Change	What to do	Where
Jackson 3 is the default; packages and group ids moved from `com.fasterxml.jackson` to **`tools.jackson`** (annotations such as `@JsonProperty` keep `com.fasterxml.jackson.annotation`)	fix imports; `ObjectMapper` usage mostly becomes `JsonMapper`	5.5
`Jackson2ObjectMapperBuilderCustomizer` → `JsonMapperBuilderCustomizer`; `@JsonComponent` → `@JacksonComponent`; `@JsonMixin` → `@JacksonMixin`	rename	5.5
JSON-specific parser/generator features moved from `spring.jackson.parser.*` / `generator.*` to **`spring.jackson.json.read.*`** / **`spring.jackson.json.write.*`** (`spring.jackson.read.*` / `write.*` remain for format-neutral stream features); `spring.jackson.use-jackson2-defaults=true` restores Jackson 2 behaviour	update properties	5.5
Jackson 2 still possible through the **deprecated** `spring-boot-jackson2` module (`spring.jackson2.*`); Framework plans to disable its auto-detection in 7.1 and remove it in 7.2	migrate now	5.5
`HttpMessageConverters` bean type deprecated	use `ServerHttpMessageConvertersCustomizer` / `ClientHttpMessageConvertersCustomizer`	Chapter 5

Null-safety, testing, and other code changes

Change	What to do	Where
Boot and Framework annotated with **JSpecify** (`@NullMarked`, `@Nullable`); Spring's own `org.springframework.lang.Nullable` deprecated	use `org.jspecify.annotations` in your code; Kotlin and null checkers may flag new warnings	2.13
`@MockBean` / `@SpyBean` **removed**	`@MockitoBean` / `@MockitoSpyBean`	Chapter 12
`@SpringBootTest` no longer sets up MockMvc, `WebTestClient` or `TestRestTemplate` on its own	add `@AutoConfigureMockMvc`, `@AutoConfigureRestTestClient`, `@AutoConfigureTestRestTemplate`	Chapter 12
`TestRestTemplate` moved to `org.springframework.boot.resttestclient` (module `spring-boot-resttestclient`)	fix imports, or switch to the new **`RestTestClient`**	1.12
`EnvironmentPostProcessor` moved to `org.springframework.boot`; `BootstrapRegistry` to `org.springframework.boot.bootstrap`	update imports and `spring.factories`	Chapter 3
Spring Retry no longer version-managed	declare its version, or move to Framework 7 `@Retryable`	4.7
Spring Authorization Server moved into Spring Security 7 (`spring-authorization-server.version` property gone)	use `spring-security.version`	11.14

Property renames and changed defaults (the most common)

Before (3.x)	After (4.x)
`spring.jackson.parser.*`, `spring.jackson.generator.*`	`spring.jackson.json.read.*`, `spring.jackson.json.write.*`
`spring.data.mongodb.host` / `.port` / `.uri` / `.database` / ...	`spring.mongodb.host` / `.port` / `.uri` / `.database` / ...
`management.health.mongo.enabled`	`management.health.mongodb.enabled`
`server.error.*` (`include-stacktrace`, `include-message`, `path`, `whitelabel.enabled`, ...)	`spring.web.error.*` — the old keys are no longer bound since 4.0.0
`spring.session.redis.*`	`spring.session.data.redis.*` (Spring Session MongoDB left Boot, see below)
`spring.dao.exceptiontranslation.enabled`	`spring.persistence.exceptiontranslation.enabled`
`spring.kafka.retry.topic.backoff.random`	`spring.kafka.retry.topic.backoff.jitter`
DevTools LiveReload on by default	`spring.devtools.livereload.enabled` defaults to **`false`** (and LiveReload is deprecated in 4.1)
Kubernetes liveness/readiness probes only on Kubernetes	health **probes enabled by default** (`management.endpoint.health.probes.enabled`) — Chapter 15
`server.forward-headers-strategy` applied to war deployments (apps packaged as `.war` files and installed into a separate servlet server)	no longer applies to wars — register a `ForwardedHeaderFilter` yourself

Removed features

Removed in Boot 4.0	Replacement
Undertow	Tomcat or Jetty
executable "fully executable" jar launch scripts	run with `java -jar`, systemd, containers
Maven `CLASSIC` loader implementation	the default loader
optional dependencies packed into the uber jar (the single "fat" jar containing the app and all its libraries)	`<includeOptional>true</includeOptional>` if you really need them
Spock integration (Groovy 5 incompatibility)	**back in Boot 4.1** with Spock 2.4
Spring Session Hazelcast / MongoDB (moved to those vendors)	the vendors' own modules
Pulsar reactive support	Spring Pulsar imperative API

New in Boot 4.0

Feature	Where
API versioning auto-configuration (`spring.mvc.apiversion.*`, `spring.webflux.apiversion.*`)	5.9
HTTP service clients auto-configured: `@ImportHttpServices` + `spring.http.serviceclient.<group>.*`	6.6
`spring.http.clients.*` for the auto-configured HTTP client library and timeouts	6.4
`RestTestClient` in tests	1.12, Chapter 12
`spring-boot-starter-opentelemetry` (OTLP metrics and traces)	Chapter 15
`JmsClient` auto-configuration	Chapter 14
several `TaskDecorator` beans combined automatically	Chapter 14
`logging.console.enabled=false` to turn console logging off	Chapter 15
Kotlin serialization starter	—

Self-check

1. You upgrade and your app no longer runs Flyway migrations. Why? → Boot 4 auto-configures Flyway only with `spring-boot-starter-flyway`.
2. `@MockBean` no longer compiles. Replacement? → `@MockitoBean` (and `@MockitoSpyBean` for `@SpyBean`).
3. Why does `import com.fasterxml.jackson.databind.ObjectMapper` fail? → Boot 4 uses Jackson 3 in `tools.jackson.*`; only the annotations kept the old package.
4. Your `@SpringBootTest` can no longer inject `MockMvc`. Fix? → Add `@AutoConfigureMockMvc`.

17.14 Spring Framework 6 → 7

Area	What changed in 7.0	Where
baselines	Java 17 (25 recommended), Jakarta EE 11, Servlet 6.1, JPA 3.2, Bean Validation 3.1, Kotlin 2.2, GraalVM 25, Netty 4.2, JUnit 6	1.4
null-safety	whole codebase annotated with **JSpecify**, including generics, arrays and varargs; JSR 305-style Spring annotations deprecated	2.13
programmatic beans	new `BeanRegistrar` contract for registering beans with code (loops, conditions)	2.14
resilience	`RetryTemplate` / `RetryPolicy` in `spring-core` (`org.springframework.core.retry`), `@Retryable` and `@ConcurrencyLimit` in `spring-context`, enabled with `@EnableResilientMethods`; `@Retryable` also adapts to reactive return types	4.7
proxies	CGLIB (the library that creates proxies by generating subclasses) default applied consistently to all proxy processors (including `@Async`); `@Proxyable` overrides per bean	4.4
API versioning	first-class in Spring MVC and WebFlux: resolve the version from header, query parameter, path segment or media type; deprecation hints; client-side support in `RestClient`, `WebClient`, HTTP interfaces; testing support	5.9, 6.7
HTTP interface clients	group-based configuration with `@ImportHttpServices` and `HttpServiceGroupConfigurer`; `InputStream` / `OutputStream` support	6.6
`RestTemplate`	deprecated in the reference docs in 7.0, `@Deprecated` planned for 7.1, removal in 8.0	6.1
Jackson 3	default JSON library across MVC, WebFlux, messaging; Jackson 2 support deprecated	5.5
message converters	new `HttpMessageConverters` builder API (`configureMessageConverters(ServerBuilder)`)	Chapter 5
path matching	`PathMatcher` / `AntPathMatcher` for MVC mappings deprecated in favour of `PathPattern`, which now supports `/**` at the start of a pattern; suffix-pattern and trailing-slash matching options removed	5.3
`HttpHeaders`	no longer a `MultiValueMap`; some map methods removed	Chapter 5
data access	JPA 3.2: inject `EntityManagerFactory` / `EntityManager` with `@Autowired`; Hibernate 7 support moved to `orm.jpa.hibernate`; `JdbcClient` gains fetch size, max rows, query timeout	Chapter 7, Chapter 8
messaging	new **`JmsClient`** (like `JdbcClient` / `RestClient` for JMS)	Chapter 14
testing	**`RestTestClient`** (non-reactive `WebTestClient`), test application contexts **paused** when not in use, `@MockitoBean` on non-singleton beans, better `@Nested` injection	Chapter 12
SpEL (Spring Expression Language, the `#{...}` expressions)	`Optional` support with `?.` and Elvis (`?:`, "use this default if null"); since 7.0.8 a default limit of 10,000 operations per evaluation	—

Area	What changed in 7.0	Where
Java 24+	bytecode metadata read with the JDK **Class-File API** (JEP 484) — transparent	Java Ch. 17
removed	`javax.annotation` / `javax.inject` support (use `jakarta.*`), `spring-jcl` (Apache Commons Logging 1.3 instead), `ListenableFuture` (use `CompletableFuture`), OkHttp3 support, `Theme` support, `webjars-locator-core` (use `webjars-locator-lite`), Undertow-specific classes	2.15
deprecated	JUnit 4 support (`SpringRunner`, ...), `<mvc:*>` XML namespace, document/feed views (PDF, XLS, RSS), BeanShell	—

In the interview

Q: What's new in Spring Framework 7 / Boot 4? → Jakarta EE 11 and Java 17 baseline (25 recommended); JSpecify null-safety; built-in API versioning; HTTP service client groups with Boot auto-configuration; core resilience (`@Retryable`, `@ConcurrencyLimit`, `RetryTemplate`); `BeanRegistrar`; Jackson 3; `RestTestClient`; and in Boot, modular auto-configuration with a starter and test starter per technology.

- *Follow-up: what breaks first when you upgrade?* → Jackson imports (`tools.jackson`), renamed starters (web → webmvc, aop → aspectj), Flyway needing its starter, removed `@MockBean`, `javax.*` annotations, and `.and()`-style security configuration.
- *Follow-up: do you still need Spring Retry?* → Usually not: Framework 7's `@Retryable` covers retries with backoff and jitter. For circuit breakers use Resilience4j (Chapter 16).

17.15 Spring Security 6 → 7

Change	Details	Where
lambda DSL only	`.and()` chaining removed; one lambda per feature	10.3
`authorizeRequests()` removed	use `authorizeHttpRequests()` (built on `AuthorizationManager`)	10.3
`AntPathRequestMatcher`, `MvcRequestMatcher` removed	**`PathPatternRequestMatcher`** (same syntax as Spring MVC)	10.3
`AccessDecisionManager` / voters	moved out of the main jar to the legacy `spring-security-access` module; use `AuthorizationManager`	10.6
multi-factor authentication	every login mechanism adds a factor authority (`FACTOR_PASSWORD`, `FACTOR_OTT`, `FACTOR_WEBAUTHN`); `@EnableMultiFactorAuthentication` or `AuthorizationManagerFactories.multiFactor()` require several factors	10.4
CSRF for single-page apps	`csrf(c -> c.spa())`	10.8
password encoders	Password4j-based encoders (Argon2, bcrypt, scrypt, PBKDF2, balloon hashing)	10.5
Spring Authorization Server	now shipped inside Spring Security 7	11.14
OAuth2 password grant	client support removed	11.2
PKCE	used by default for confidential clients too	11.9
JWT	`NimbusJwtEncoder.withKeyPair(...)` / `withSecretKey(...)` builders; `JwtTypeValidator` checks the `typ` header	11.3, 11.4
HTTP interfaces + OAuth2	`@ClientRegistrationId` on a whole HTTP interface	11.10
7.1 (in Boot 4.1)	`RestClientOpaqueTokenIntrospector`; `charset` parameter in `WWW-Authenticate: Basic`	11.7, 10.1

17.16 What Boot 4.1 adds (June 2026)

Change in 4.1	Notes	Where
everything **deprecated in 4.0 removed**	upgrade 4.0 → 4.1 with zero deprecation warnings first	—
`layertools` jar mode removed	use the `tools` jar mode for layered images	Chapter 15
gRPC (Google's binary remote-procedure-call protocol) support (server and client, Netty or Servlet over HTTP/2)	new	—
Spock support back (Spock 2.4, Groovy 5)		Chapter 12
`spring.datasource.connection-fetch=lazy`	wraps the pool in `LazyConnectionDataSourceProxy`: no connection taken until the first statement	7.2
`@ConfigurationProperties` records bind `Optional` parameters as `Optional.empty()` instead of `null`		3.6
`spring.security.oauth2.resourceserver.jwt.authorities-claim-expressions`	map authorities from JWT claims with properties	11.5
observability: context propagation into `@Async` methods, `management.opentelemetry.*` properties, Kafka/RabbitMQ observation conventions		Chapter 15
HTTP clients: cookie handling (`spring.http.clients.cookie-handling`), `InetAddressFilter` against SSRF (server-side request forgery: tricking a server into calling internal addresses)		Chapter 6
`@RedisListener` auto-configuration		Chapter 9
dependency upgrades: Hibernate 7.4, Spring Data 2026.0, Micrometer 1.17		Chapter 8
deprecated: DevTools LiveReload, Derby support		—

Common migration mistakes

- Jumping from Boot 2.7 straight to 4.x. Go 2.7 → 3.5 (the `javax` → `jakarta` step) → 4.x.
- Ignoring startup warnings after the upgrade. Removed auto-configuration usually shows up as "bean not found", not as a compile error.
- Keeping `spring-boot-properties-migrator` in production.
- Upgrading Boot but not the separately versioned projects: **Spring Cloud** needs its 2025.1 "Oakwood" train for Boot 4 (2025.1.2 or later for Boot 4.1) (Chapter 16), **Spring AI** needs 2.0, **springdoc-openapi** needs its Boot 4 line (5.12).

17.17 In the interview — quick round

Question	30-second answer
What is Spring AI?	A Spring project giving portable APIs (`ChatModel`, `ChatClient`, `EmbeddingModel`, `VectorStore`) and Boot starters for AI providers, plus advisors for memory, RAG and tool calling. (§17.1)
`ChatModel` vs `ChatClient`?	Provider-level interface vs fluent API with templates, advisors, tools, structured output. (§17.3)
How does chat memory work?	The model is stateless; an advisor stores messages per conversation id and re-sends a window of them. (§17.6)
How do you get a Java object from an LLM?	`.entity(MyRecord.class)`: JSON Schema instructions + Jackson parsing; native structured output where supported. (§17.7)
Who executes a tool?	The application. The model only requests the call; `ToolCallingAdvisor` runs it and loops. (§17.8)
How do you test Spring AI code without paying?	A fake `ChatModel` bean with canned answers; real-model evaluations separately. (§17.2)
Main Boot 4 changes?	Modular starters, Jackson 3, JSpecify, Jakarta EE 11, API versioning, HTTP service clients, `@MockitoBean`, Undertow removed. (§17.13)
Main Framework 7 changes?	JSpecify, API versioning, `@ImportHttpServices`, `@Retryable` / `@ConcurrencyLimit`, `BeanRegistrar`, `RestTestClient`, Jackson 3. (§17.14)
Main Security 7 changes?	Lambda DSL only, `PathPatternRequestMatcher`, MFA factors, Authorization Server included, password grant removed. (§17.15)

Chapter TL;DR

- **Spring AI 2.0.x** is the version for Boot 4.x: BOM + one model starter + `spring.ai.<provider>.api-key` / `.chat.model` (e.g. `gpt-5-mini`, `claude-sonnet-5-5`, `claude-opus-5-5`). Set the model explicitly.
- `ChatClient` over `ChatModel`; prompts are messages (system, user, assistant, tool); `PromptTemplate` fills `{placeholders}` and fails on missing values.
- **Advisors** are the extension point: logging, memory (pass `ChatMemory.CONVERSATION_ID`), RAG (`QuestionAnswerAdvisor` + threshold + filters), tool calling (auto-registered in 2.0), your own (redaction). Order matters.
- **Structured output** with `.entity(...)`; **tools** with `@Tool` (authorize inside, limits 40/150); **MCP** to share tools across processes (`@McpTool`, Streamable HTTP).
- Everything above the model runs offline against a **fake** `ChatModel` — 14 tests in this chapter prove it.
- **Boot 3 → 4**: go via 3.5, run OpenRewrite, rename starters (webmvc, aspectj, security-oauth2-*), add test and Flyway starters, move to Jackson 3 (`tools.jackson`), `@MockitoBean`, JSpecify, Jakarta EE 11; Undertow gone.
- **Framework 7**: API versioning, HTTP service groups, core resilience, `BeanRegistrar`, `RestTestClient`, JSpecify; `RestTemplate` on its way out.
- **Security 7**: lambda DSL only, `authorizeHttpRequests`, `PathPatternRequestMatcher`, MFA, Authorization Server inside.

Next: Chapter 18 — Spring interview questions turns the whole book into questions and answers for revision.